this transition. At 5.93 million, they account for 67 per cent of Delhi's active vehicles and are used intensively, from daily commuting to last-mile delivery, making this segment the quickest lever for accelerating EV adoption and delivering visible gains in air quality. Scrappage incentives for cars, too, address legacy pollution rather than simply adding cleaner vehicles. At present, in Delhi, petrol vehicles are permitted to ply for 15 years and diesel ones for 10 years, after which they must be deregistered.

The Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM), the apex body representing the country's vehicle and engine makers, has described the draft policy as "mission-oriented" while raising concerns about its over-reliance on mandates. "We at SIAM believe that enablers are the best way to promote EV adoption, not mandates," says SIAM president Shailesh Chandra. The industry body is preparing a response to the draft policy to address these concerns.

THE LIMITS OF THE SWITCH

For buyers, the transition increasingly turns on one factor: charging. The case for electric two-wheelers has strengthened, but it rests less on upfront cost and more on whether charging is dependable, accessible and quick. On this front, the policy's outline appears thinner than the scale of the shift it seeks to enable. Delhi Transco Limited has been tasked with planning and deploying public charging and battery-swapping infrastructure, alongside a proposed single-window clearance system for charging station operators. EV dealers will be required to instal at least one public charging station, with a minimum of three charging points for two- and three-wheelers as well as two for cars. But the draft policy is silent on the timelines.

Delhi has roughly 3,100 EV charging stations—that together host fewer than 10,000 charging points—and about 893 battery swapping stations. Against a stated target of 18,000 charging points, this leaves a shortfall of at least 8,000. Moreover, availability and reliability remain uneven. "There are too few chargers and many of them don't work when you need them," says Radheshyam Prasad, a Sangam Vihar resident who works as a delivery agent for a food aggregator and also plies his electric bike for a ride-share platform. Prasad needs to access a charger "quite a few times a day" and often worries about getting "stuck without charge in an area that has no charger". However, Pradeep Jalan, a CR Park resident who drives a high-end BYD electric sedan, reports little difficulty. "Most charging happens at home overnight, and at my office in the day. On the off chance that I need a public charger, Delhi has enough."

Beyond infrastructure, broader questions remain about what electrification can—and cannot—solve. "While EVs are all good from a local pollution reduction perspective, more personal vehicles—cars especially—mean the problem of congestion and health concerns do not get addressed," says Geetam Tiwari, TRIPP (Transportation Research and Injury Prevention Centre) chair professor at IIT Delhi. "And at a larger level, unless we switch to cleaner electricity, more EVs in India only add to emissions from coal-based power plants." More fundamentally, electrification changes what powers vehicles, not how many are on the road. While the policy includes steps to electrify buses, it does not shift commuters away from personal vehicles. Tiwari's conclusion is unambiguous: "Switching to cars is not the long-term solution. Switching to public transport is."

Compared with other states, Delhi's approach is more directive, relying on phased bans without setting a clear adoption target. Maharashtra's 2025–2030 policy aims for 30 per cent EV penetration by 2030 and leans on incentives rather than restrictions on new internal combustion engine (ICE) vehicle registrations. Karnataka, an early mover on road tax exemptions, has introduced a graded lifetime tax on EVs from April 2026. In Norway, often cited as a benchmark, incentives are being scaled back as adoption matures rather than giving way to bans. By contrast, Delhi plans to remove the petrol option in phases and expects the market to adjust. The approach can accelerate change, but unevenly—a proposition likely to be tested in ongoing deliberations over the draft policy. ■



ARUN KUMAR

THE CHARGING CHALLENGE

Delhi lags far behind in charging points to fuel EVs

3,100
Public charging stations in Delhi, with fewer than 10,000 charging points

18,000
Targeted charging points, set prior to the new draft EV policy

8,000
The current estimated shortfall in charging points

> **"Unless we switch to cleaner electricity, more EVs will only add to emissions from coal-based power plants"**
>
> **GEETAM TIWARI,** *TRIPP Chair Professor, Department of Civil Engineering, IIT Delhi*